

Glossary

Adaptation A feature of an animal that evolved in response to its environment or way of life. The long neck of a giraffe, for instance, is an adaptation that helps it reach treetops.

Algae Primitive plants and plant-like organisms that grow in wet conditions.

Amber The fossil form of a sticky resin made by certain trees. Perfectly preserved insects and other organisms have been found in amber.

Ammonites Prehistoric sea creatures with coiled, chambered shells. Ammonites were relatives of octopuses and squids.

Amphibian A type of cold-blooded vertebrate, such as frog or newt. Most amphibians develop from larvae that live in water and breathe through gills, becoming land-dwelling adults that breathe air through lungs.

Ancestor An animal or plant species from which a more recent species has evolved.

Angiosperms A scientific term for flowering plants. This group includes broad-leaved trees and grasses.

Ankylosaurs Four-legged, armoured, plant-eating dinosaurs with bony plates that covered the neck, shoulders, and back.

Archosaurs A major group of reptiles that originated in the Triassic Period. It includes dinosaurs, pterosaurs, and crocodylomorphs.

Arthropods Invertebrates with segmented bodies and a hard outer covering (exoskeleton). Extinct arthropods include trilobites and eurypterids. Living ones include insects and spiders.

Aurochs An extinct variety of wild cattle that was the ancestor of modern cattle.

Australopithecus A prehistoric member of the human family that may be a direct ancestor of modern humans. *Australopithecus* looked like a chimpanzee but walked upright like a human.

Bivalves Aquatic animals such as clams and oysters that live in a hinged shell. The two halves of the shell are usually mirror images of each other.

Bony fish (Osteichthyans) Fish with a skeleton made of bone. Some fish, such as sharks, have a skeleton made of cartilage rather than bone and are classed as cartilaginous fish.

Burgess Shale Formation A site in British Columbia, Canada, where many important Cambrian fossils were discovered. Among the 130 species identified are sponges, jellyfish, worms, and arthropods.

Cambrian The first period of the Palaeozoic Era, from 542 to 488 million years ago. This was when most of the main invertebrate groups appeared in the fossil record.

Camouflage Colours or patterns on an animal's skin or fur that help it to blend with its surroundings and hide.

Carboniferous The fifth period of the Palaeozoic Era, from 359 to 299 million years ago. During this period, forests covered the land and were inhabited by insects and four-legged vertebrates (tetrapods), including the first amphibians and the first reptiles.

Carnivore An animal that eats meat. The term carnivore can also refer to a specific family of mammals (the order Carnivora).

Cartilage A firm, rubber-like tissue that is part of the skeleton of vertebrates. In fish such as sharks, the entire skeleton is made of cartilage.

Cephalopod Sea creatures with big eyes and a well-developed head surrounded by a ring of tentacles. Examples include octopuses, squid, cuttlefish, and ammonites.

Ceratopsians Two-legged and four-legged, plant-eating dinosaurs with a deep beak and a bony frill at the rear of the skull. They include the horned dinosaurs.

Chelicerate A type of invertebrate with special mouthparts called chelicerae that are used as pincers or fangs. Modern examples include spiders and scorpions.

Cold-blooded An animal is described as cold-blooded if its body temperature rises and falls along with the outside temperature. Animals that maintain a constant body temperature are described as warm-blooded.

Cretaceous The last period of the Mesozoic Era, from 145 to 65 million years ago.

Crinoids (sea lilies) Plant-shaped sea creatures with feathery arms that live anchored to the sea floor by long stalks. They are related to starfish and sea urchins.

Crocodylomorphs A group of reptiles that includes crocodiles, alligators, and their many extinct relatives. Crocodylomorphs appeared at about the same time as the dinosaurs and were once much more varied than today.

Crustaceans A large and varied group of arthropods, most of which live in water. Living examples include crabs, shrimps, and woodlice.

Cycads Palm-like, seed-bearing plants that are topped by a crown of fern-like leaves. They may be short and shrub-like, or grow as high as 20 m (65 ft).

Descendant An animal or plant species that evolved from an early species (its ancestor).

Devonian period The fourth period of the Palaeozoic Era, from 416 to 350 million years ago. The Devonian is also called the "age of fish". During this period, tetrapods (four-legged vertebrates) evolved from fish.

Digit A finger, thumb, or toe.

